

Gothic art

The term 'Gothic art' originated among historians who believed that the Goths had been responsible for the styles of the period. As Goths were barbarian tribes, 'Gothic' was used in a disparaging sense. Developing from Romanesque, its styles grew out of architecture, which developed between c.1100 and 1500 as a means of glorifying God. As the European feudal system became more organized, a new, wealthy middle class began to expand. The first universities were established, and the mood across Europe was hopeful.

Gothic art primarily aimed to teach the illiterate about Christianity and inspire them with God's grandeur. With tall spires, flying buttresses and pointed arches, churches were built to point up at heaven, and their ornamental interiors were bathed in coloured light from huge stained glass windows (as at Chartres Cathedral). Originating in France and then spreading across Europe, Gothic art was expressed in panel paintings, frescoes, illuminated manuscripts, statues, stained glass and tapestries.



Portail royal of Chartres Cathedral, mid-12th century